



ONE WAY

SPECTRUM '25-'26

SABRET

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# SPECTRUM '25 - '26

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## CONTRIBUTORS

(in alphabetical order by last name)

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LUCA CHILLEMI  
SAM CHOI  
MATHEUS DE BARROS  
HENRY FOUCAND  
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COVER BY JOSH MOORMAN

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To those who contributed  
artwork: thank you for sharing  
your vision, courage, and  
creativity. Your work gives these  
pages color, texture, and life.

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# A note from the moderator



“Free to be Me.”

Art does not exist in a vacuum. It is a living, breathing dialogue between the creator and the observer. In this edition, our student contributors have laid bare their vulnerabilities, curiosities, and triumphs through striking visual art, poetry, and prose.

The unintentional theme of this issue is Free to be Me. Within these pages, you will find creators navigating the delicate space between the past and the future. You will encounter artistic pieces that capture the fleeting light of dusk, and essays that dissect the quiet moments of personal change.

We extend our deepest gratitude to the creators who trusted us with their work, and to those who spent countless hours reading, selecting, and designing this issue. Most of all, we thank our faculty advisor Ms. Verhagen, activities director Mr. Durning, our headmaster Mr. Gallo, and Monsignor Kelly for giving us the opportunity to express ourselves through the creative process. Special thanks to Corey Masklee '10 for his design and layout expertise in making the pages come to life.

Turn these pages with an open mind. Hopefully they spark conversation, offer solace, and inspire your own creative journey.

Enjoy!





## The Commuter

— Luca Chillemi

He rolls from bed when the skies still gray,  
 Puts on his tie to start the day.  
 He grabs his bag and slips outside,  
 As dad starts up the early ride.  
 Through traffic and crowds, they slowly glide  
 He watches the world from the passenger side.  
 He checks the board to find his track,  
 Back on the rails with his heavy pack.  
 He steps abroad with commuters in stride,  
 Youngest among them, standing tall with pride.  
 He feels his life is on replay track,  
 Each morning forward, each night back.  
 In that loop a thought breaks through,  
 The rails may bend to something new.  
 For every ride that feels the same,  
 Still carries him towards who he became.



## Friends

— Owen Pipher

They cheer me up when everything feels wrong.  
 They help me get through the hardest days.  
 Sometimes they make me sad; sometimes they make me  
 mad. But somehow, they always make me laugh.  
 They're there for the good times, and in the bad ones, too.  
 Through every bad and good moment, they are by my side.  
 No matter how far, they show up.  
 They stand by my side; that's why they are my friends.



## Ella

—Owen Pipher

The first to greet me,  
 no matter the day— A loyal friend to the end.  
 We can all learn a lot from this three-legged friend:  
 Resilience and strength, to name a few.  
 No matter what life can take away,  
 She proves we are more than what we've lost.

# Hockey

—Dominic Watson

The rink smells like cold and rubber  
And something else  
I can never quite figure out.  
Coach says keep it simple but nothing  
About this game is simple  
When someone is charging at you  
With full speed  
And you have to decide in half a second

I play defense so no one notices  
Sophomore year I took a stick to the mouth  
And split a tooth into my glove  
Just looked at it for a second  
Then went to the bench.  
Last Tuesday we won the final

And we all pilled on Noah  
I don't even know how to explain this sport  
It's just ice and a stick and a puck  
But when it's happening  
It feels like the only real thing.



# The Winning Point

—Owen Pipher

The stands are packed.  
My team is down by one, with only seconds left on the clock. Everybody is holding their breath.  
The ball is passed in; it finds the right hands.  
He has a chance—one shot to win it all.  
He waits a little, takes a breath, and shoots.  
The ball arcs in the air; it looks like it's going in.  
The crowd falls silent.  
For a second, it looks like a perfect shot.  
It hits the rim—in and out.  
The buzzer sounds. The game is lost.



# Pressure on the Tee

—Luca Gondevas

In the tee box I stand  
With my driver in my hand.  
I hit the ball long and far,  
Hoping to achieve par.

I get an eagle,  
This much fun should be illegal.  
The greens are lush,  
The greens are plush,  
Everyone on the course is hush hush.

The weight of watching eyes begins to press,  
The tension between me and the ball  
becomes dense.  
A calming breath, my stance in place,  
Closing my eyes, I find my grace.



# Soccer Haiku

—Chase LaPointe

Cleats carve up the grass  
Crowds roar as the net ripples  
Dust and dreams collide

# Surfing Under the Sun

—Luca Gondevas

I lie on my surfboard looking out into the sea,  
Crystal clear blue water lies under me.  
Feeling the sunlight hit my back,  
I watch the waves in front of me stack.  
I feel the cool air and the wind hit my face,  
The peace of the ocean, its warm embrace.  
The water is crisp and cool to the touch,  
I forgot this feeling, how I missed it so much.  
The seagulls are singing a sweet bird song,  
As I ride the wave for so very long.

# Harsh Reality

—David Lopes

Football was my first thing.  
Cold practices, long nights, stiff pads,  
Hearing my dad yell my name from the sideline.  
Leaving it feels wrong,  
Turning my back on the person I wanted to be,  
The dreams I had as a kid faded away.  
But wrestling is where I'm better.  
On the mat it's clearer,  
Hard work pays off,  
And I can feel myself getting sharper.  
That's what makes it hard.  
I don't want to let go of football,  
But I can go further in wrestling if I don't.  
So, I'm choosing the harder reality,  
And letting the old dream hurt a little.  
Football raised me,  
Wrestling is where I grow now.

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*Me:*  
*Living Hazard Zet Forward*  
—NathaBniel Matus

Throughout my life I have been through diversity and learned the importance of values and standards. I am a football player, but I was a competitive swimmer from age seven to thirteen. Being a double sport athlete allowed me to understand the importance of commitment and hard work. I also understood at a young age that everything is gifted to me in life. Some people are gifted the ability to understand math and science or English and history while others are gifted in athletics or the arts. But, no one will get anywhere no matter how gifted without hard work.

During my training for swimming, I went to nine to ten practices a week, two hours long, before and after school. Yes, waking up at 4:10 in the morning wasn't easy at all, especially before school, but I still got up and pushed my body to swim to the best of my ability. I was able to do that because of the hard work ethic instilled in me, it is something that I loved and it was my commitment to the sport. During football season I practiced in the boiling heat and freezing cold, I put in extra hours and trained outside of practice as well. I also constantly studied game films to become a better player. I did this because I loved it, and it was my devotion to the sport. That is an aspect I bring to Seton Hall Prep, hard work and dedication while helping my peers and teammates to keep pushing and not to give up.

My entire life I grew up without a father, but my mom's dad stepped in, my grandfather. He raised me like a son, and we shared a very special bond. He taught me a lot of things about having commitments and how to be a good person. My grandpa was in the army for twenty-eight years. Some people would think that being in the military for that long would make someone a tough guy but that was not the case. He was the most caring person in the world. He always looked out for people and put their needs ahead of his. My grandpa lived up north in Vernon, New Jersey. So, when he wasn't around and I needed a father figure, that is when my step-dad to be Paul was there for me. He has been there for me since I was seven years old. For the past seven years, Paul has raised me like his own son. Teaching me the importance of being there for people when they are at a low point in their life, being disciplined, and staying true to my morals.

Sadly, on Thanksgiving in 2023 my grandpa passed away in his sleep. Nothing has ever hurt me so badly, I lost my best friend, my confidant, my mentor, my everything. Today I carry him with me through the halls of Seton Hall Prep by sticking to my standards, by caring for my peers and teammates, and by remaining optimistic especially during low points.



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## Stress Sonnet

—Chase LaPointe

When deadlines press like thunder in air,  
And ticking clocks grow loud inside my head,  
Each whispered doubt becomes a heavy glare,  
Each restless thought refuses to be dead.

The day demands a hundred fractured parts,  
A thousand parade before my sight,  
They crowd the corners of my anxious heart  
And steal the mercy of the coming night.

Sleep hovers near but will not settle long,  
It flits away on currents sharp with fear,  
My pulse conducts a thin, unsteady song  
That only I can truly seem to hear.

Yet dawn arrives with quiet, patient breath,  
And proves no storm can reign in endless depth.

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## A Summer Night

—Luca Chillemi

A summer night a chilly breeze,  
Water reaching to our knees,  
The deep dark skies overhead,  
Sand in our shoes, no thoughts of beds,

Jersey Mikes in our hands,  
Around bonfires in the sand,  
Each laugh and spark beneath the moon,  
Becomes a memory far too soon ,

Laughter filling in the streets,  
Boardwalk food stuck in our teeth,  
Flip flops tapping on wooden planks,  
Ocean breeze and midnight thanks,

Wawa nights, bright and loud,  
Hoodies on in a happy crowd,  
Jersey nights etched in my brain,  
Same old shore, but not the same.

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## Comparison

—Matheus DeBarros

**C**lick and scroll—each post I see,  
**O**n my feed, a life better than mine.  
**M**ore is asked when less is meant,  
**P**utting others before yourself.  
**A**ccommodating to the world,  
**R**eally never becoming who you want to be.  
**I**solation and lonely nights,  
**S**pent comparing to others' life.  
**O**nline likes and goals to meet,  
**N**ever feeling whole.  
**B**ut one day I'll look away.  
**M**aybe find my own path, and I hope that's soon.

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## Just a Screen

—Lorenzo Reed

I wake up and I check my phone,  
Before I even leave my bed,  
A million perfect lives are shown,  
All brighter than the one I've led.

They post their pictures every night,  
The parties packed with shining smiles,  
Their screen glows up like a light,  
Their perfect looks and trending styles.

I count my likes I hope for more,  
Refresh the page to hear the lore,  
Each little heart I can't ignore  
Still leaves me wanting something more.



# Temporary

## —Lorenzo Reed

"It's only temporary Julie, okay? You can survive with dad," she said with a soft, convincing tone.

"But mom, I don't want to stay with dad! He's... embarrassing," I pouted.

"You'll be with me in June. You'll only be here for four months," Mom replied. "I know you don't like him, but it'll be over before you know it."

We exchanged goodbyes and she left me alone with my boring dad. His existence was the reason why I did not have a normal life. That I did not have the nicest of clothes, the best of friends, or the happiness others grow up with. At least this is only temporary.

I walked into my dad's cramped apartment with an obnoxious flickering light in my face. The rattling pipes, stale smell, and run-down bedroom that I would be spending the next four months in made me want to leave that instant.

"I know it's not the best, but I tried to make it nice for you. It's hard getting a nice apartment in New York City on a minimum wage pay, I'm sorry. Maybe we can go out to dinner tonight?" my dad asked, clearly self-conscious. I knew he tried his best, but I still hated his guts for the divorce and how my life has been ever since. "Maybe some Chinese takeout?"

"No thanks, I'm not hungry," I answered angrily, as I slammed the door. Mom's apartment in Los Angeles would have been beautiful with soft lights, the warm sun, and nice white bedding. Now, I am stuck in this confined space just so I can finish junior year at a school I hate. At least my life in here was only temporary.

The next morning, I woke up to find cold Chinese takeout containers outside my door. At school, I sat with the people I have sat with for over half my life. I ate the chicken sandwich my dad made as they laughed at an inside joke I was not a part of. I might have been "friends" with them through all of school, but I had always been the one behind the camera, taking the pictures. Me, walking behind them in the hallways while they talked about the girl's night I wasn't invited to. They never once asked me how I was or checked in on me while my parents were getting divorced. I could only picture a world where I am in a whole new city with new friends, going out and having fun with them in Los Angeles. At least this feeling was only temporary. I withstood seven hours of socialization until Dad picked me up in his antiquated car while blasting music, embarrassing me in front of the whole eleventh grade. I slouched and awkwardly hopped in the car, hoping my classmates would not notice me. My resentment for him grew stronger.

At home, I FaceTime Mom. We spoke about our lives and how her new job was going. When she asked me about school, I hesitated, not wanting her to know how much I despised the place, knowing she had enough on her plate. "Yeah it's going great!" I lied. "Emily and Hailey are sad that I'm leaving for senior year."

I imagined her new home through that tiny six-inch screen. I imagined her modern kitchen, with warm, hanging lights and light brown cabinets that felt like home. I compared the area to the slim, dimly lit kitchen that I was sitting in.

With nothing to do, I laid on the crusty couch and called Hailey, expecting her to answer. The phone rang twice before going to voicemail. I looked around at my unpacked things, convincing myself that this was only temporary. That my mom was right, and I would not have to unpack since the stay would be over before I realized. Then, Hailey called me back.

"Hey, what's up?" she spoke into the speaker with loud music in the background and lights streaking across her camera.

"Hey," I said, drawing out the greeting. "Where are you right now?"

"I'm at Ben's Valentine's Day party. You didn't know about it? I thought you'd come," she explained. I never knew about a party, nor was I invited.

"Oh, I didn't know that was today," I replied.

"Obviously the party is today, it's Valentine's Day, duh," she mocked. "You should still come though."

"No, that's alright. I have lots of homework to do," I tried holding my voice, looking up at the peeling white paint on the ceiling. "I'll see you tomorrow."

I hung up before she could respond. I began to cry in my hands, but I would be alright. These friends were only temporary anyway. I went to an alternate universe where I spent all afternoon with my Californian friends, eating food and finally enjoying myself. I slammed my door, prompting a response by my dad. He rhythmically knocked on the wood and I opened the locked door to him.

"Is everything okay?" he asked, looking at my red face with compassion. I shrugged. He seemed to have known what happened, but how? I had my first real hug with him in years. He offered to take me out for dinner. "It will be more fun than whatever they're doing."

He brought me to my favorite fast-food place, Shake Shack, and he knew the order that I used to get by heart. He took me to my favorite ice cream parlor and ordered the banana boat, the one I had been mentioning to my mom on FaceTime. We went to the mall, and he got me the pants that had been on my birthday wish list for weeks. He noticed every small detail and slowly, the perfect world I imagined with my mom, became reality with my dad. Week after week, our daily talks and meals at the dinner table lowered my resentment for him and I no longer noticed the peeling paint, or the flickering light, or even the rattling pipes.

Every night, I would pause for a moment before closing my door, seeing if he had anything he needed to say. The hallway to my room felt less narrow and the dull light gave me a small sense of glowing comfort. The place I usually called temporary felt like a home I did not need to leave.

One night, coming home with my dad from a joyous Bring Your Kid to Work Day, my phone buzzed, and I saw that my mom was calling. I looked at Dad, knowing my time with him was coming to an end soon. I no longer wanted to leave, and he seemed to understand through the look in my eyes. I answered, not knowing how to talk to Mom as she rarely called me now.

"Hi, Julie... yeah?" she says hurriedly as a muffled voice entered the background. A few seconds pass. "Sorry, school ends soon right? Tell me what flight you want to Los Angeles. I need to get a ticket before prices go up."

"Hi Mom! Uhm... I'm not sure yet. Do you think we can talk about this another time?" I said, trying to brush off the conversation. My dad walked away, seeming to try to give me space for my decision.

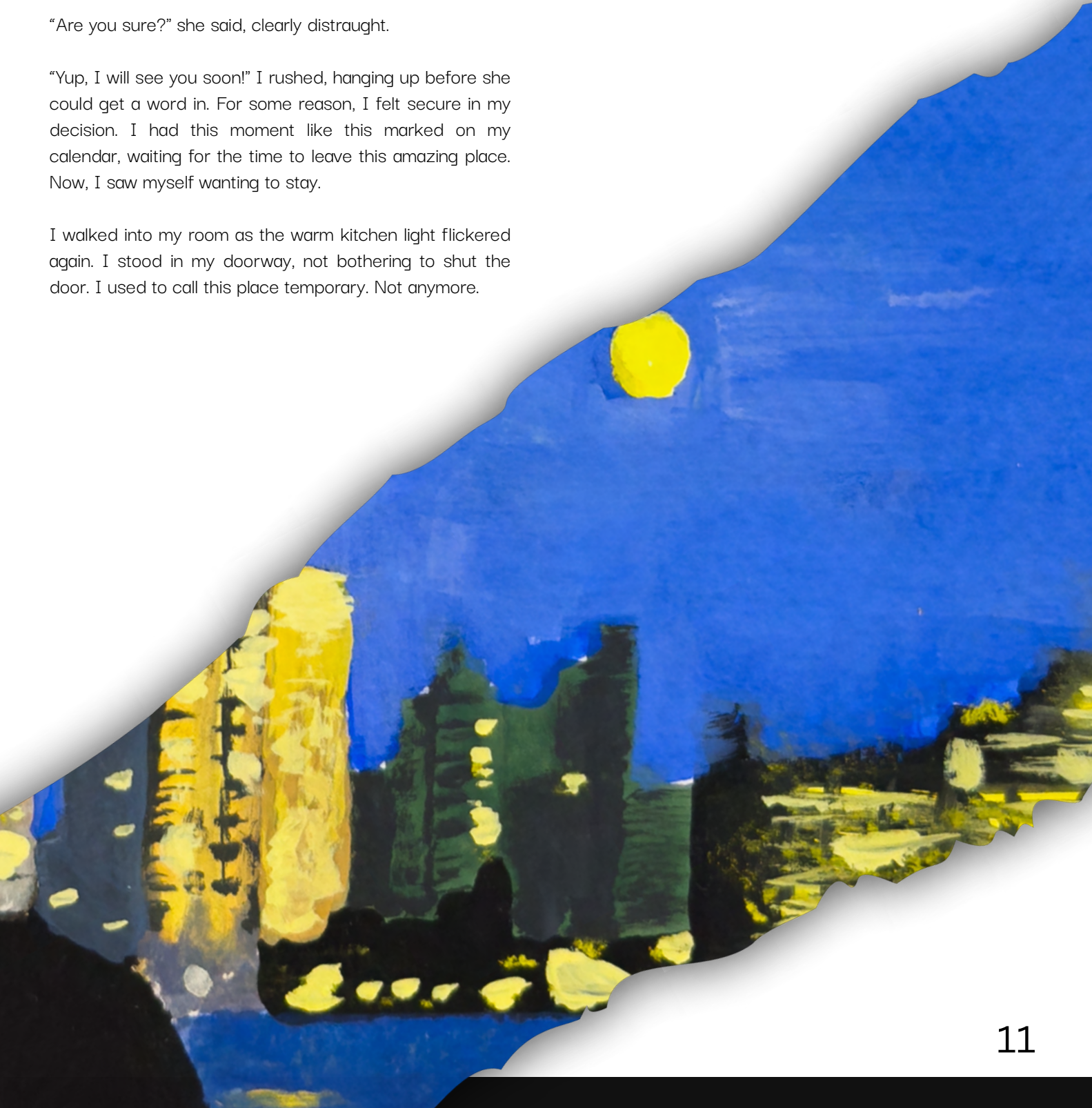
"No, sorry, I need to know now. This is one of my few times that I can even get on the phone to schedule something like this," she says, rushing me.

"Ehhh, I don't know," I said cautiously. With the experience I had with my dad, I started to like my little life with him. Although I still did not have the greatest of friends, the fanciest of clothes, or the perfect life I always imagined, I began to enjoy this life with him. I watched Dad lay down on his bed and daze at the television. "You know what Mom? Maybe I will stay. Finish senior year with my friends here."

"Are you sure?" she said, clearly distraught.

"Yup, I will see you soon!" I rushed, hanging up before she could get a word in. For some reason, I felt secure in my decision. I had this moment like this marked on my calendar, waiting for the time to leave this amazing place. Now, I saw myself wanting to stay.

I walked into my room as the warm kitchen light flickered again. I stood in my doorway, not bothering to shut the door. I used to call this place temporary. Not anymore.



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# WHITE WALLS

## —PATRICK TOBIN

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As I look around, it all feels like home, the wooden structure, the old windows, even the melancholy creases through the couch, but it is empty in a way. I do not know what it is, but it is familiar. Wait, no, it is my grandparents' home. That must be it. Although they never had a microwave, did they? At least the food is bearable and has not expired. I feel so weak. I tried opening the front door yesterday; it did not open but instead hurt. Every time I try something, it hurts. I think it's my wrists - it's like a pain, or maybe numbness. It's definitely not right. Probably from not eating; I'm so sluggish. Thankfully, along with the pain, I found this pen and notebook in the dresser of the bedroom. Not mine, or at least not the bedroom I woke up in, but the one next to me. The one with odd white walls, like a children's room but more grown-up, more visceral. It makes it somehow quieter, writing; finally, I do not have to listen to my voice. Well, it is still there, but again... quieter.

Back to the windows - it has been the same weather for my entire stay. Some sunlight would have been nice, but even the clouds are the same. Can I get some variation? The rooms are even the same, except for that damn children's room! It bothers me just to be in there, is that weird? To have a place so close but so abusive... I could never sleep there; I would truly go insane. I tried opening some of the rooms, but again it just hurts. Well, the doors are locked, but I feel weak to the point where I might not be able to open them even if they were unlocked. Due to the isolating nature of this house, I am only able to access most rooms without doors... Canned food it is!

What if I run out? I only have access to this food - the one in the pantry with some dust and cobwebs, but it's better than starving. It's right next to the living room, a bar-like area with the kitchen in the

back, a cozy counter, a nice fireplace, and a dining room, like a cabin. I would love to host a family here. When you go up the stairs, the door to the left is locked, and the one on the right is my room. Next to that... that doesn't need description. Anyway, everything else is locked. No TV. I just realized that my grandparents' house did not have a fireplace... or stairs designed that way. This is not my grandparents' house.

At the age of 25, I never thought too much about death. Sure, I had gotten into my fair share of trouble, but nothing that would make me rethink everything. Well, rethink only one thing: my life. Since writing this next little part of my journey, I'm slightly scared. Movement feels restricted. My face feels like it is in a constant yawn. I don't feel much anymore. When my parents died, I did not cry. I was just numb, and I'm not super comfortable with that, but I must live with it. I must live. I do not want to be numb; I must leave.

I had a whole life outside of here. I had friends, one named... I can't seem to remember, but he is nice, always worried about me though, made me feel inhuman. I don't like that guy. Let's leave. It's starting to hurt a lot, maybe it's my head telling me something, or it's my wrists. I continue on. The door... is it moving? Am I moving it? My wrist is on it. It hurts. Everything. Push!

White walls and ceiling. Too bright; my eyes barely open. A smooth white bed - truly an inhuman room. Odd walls... is that a camera? It is silent. I can hear too much of myself. As realization hits my face, so do tears. I look over. There is no door handle.

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# SPECTRUM NEWS

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11 September 2001

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## 8:46

—Samuel Choi

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On September 11, 2001, the sky was a beautiful blue, with a scorching sun over "The City That Never Sleeps".

Sam bought two hot coffees that morning around 8:00 A.M. One decaffeinated, one with too much sugar for his brother, Zach. They stood outside the subway, arguing about what to eat for lunch.

"Hurry up!" Zach said, as he vanished towards the towers, while Sam waited in line for the coffees.

At 8:46, the world changed.

The sound of destruction struck the city with confusion and terror. People dressed for work, dressed for school, dressed to walk their dog all looked up. Fire bloomed from the glass. Papers drifted down from the sky like snow. Sam dropped the coffees and ran to find Zach.

"Zach!" Sam screamed as the sirens were going off.

The smell of burning ash consumed the fresh air.

The second plane hit the second tower, hope was lost. People scramble towards local shops and taxis.



When the towers fell, the sky and something inside everyone collapsed within them. Debris flooded the city like a dark and evil cloud.

Zach never came home.

In the weeks after, Sam taped Zach's photo to a wall crowded with thousands of others. Strangers stood shoulder to shoulder, lighting candles, praying together, and holding hands without asking why.

This tragedy will forever stay inside Sam's memory, every time the sky turns that beautiful blue at 8:46, Sam steps outside and looks up.

He remembers the smell of the ash, he remembers his brother's smile, and he remembers how strangers reached for one another.

# ✂—7 Deadly Sins—✂

—Henry Foucand

## **Pride - "The Mirror"**

I think I'm better than the rest,  
I shine brightest, I'm the best.  
But mirrors break when you look too long,  
And soon the praise feels all wrong.

## **Greed - "Want More"**

I take and take, it's never done.  
The more I grab, the less I'm won.  
Nothing is enough to keep,  
I chase and chase, but lose in heaps.

## **Wrath - "Fire"**

A word, a look, it starts so small,  
Then anger grows and burns us all.  
I shout, I hit, I can't let go,  
And leave behind just ash and woe.

## **Envy - "Green Eyes"**

You have the stuff I wish I had,  
It makes me jealous, It makes me mad.  
But staring at what isn't mine  
Can't make me grow, can't make me shine.

## **Lust - "Pulling"**

I feel a pull I can't ignore,  
A fire that knocks me to the floor.  
It tempts, it pulls, it makes me blind,  
And leaves my better self behind.

## **Gluttony - "Never Full"**

I eat and eat, I can't stop now,  
The plate is gone, I take a bow.  
But inside me, the hunger stays,  
No matter how much food I raise.

## **Sloth - "Tomorrow"**

I say "I'll do it tomorrow,"  
And end up lying in sorrow.  
Time keeps moving, I fall behind,  
And waste the things I hoped to find.

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## The Weight of One Mistake

—Matheus DeBarros

A life of truth and of good faith,  
Dwindled down in hopeless fate.

A decision soft yet heavy too,  
May have hurt him but hurt me too.

A mistake I made I wish to take,  
Led me to a cycle I wish to break.  
Now shadows follow when I pass,  
From one mistake, a careless act.

My hands did harm and my words did too,

One apology I dare ask you.

Met with fear I ask your grace,  
Give me peace oh show your face.

The guilt I carry I can't release,  
But when with you my soul won't cease.

Comfort me oh humble Lord,  
From this story never told.

One mistake but heavy so,  
An apology I feel I owe.

Escape my mind oh dreadful thought,  
From one mistake a careless thought.



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## Forgive Me Father for I Have Sinned

—Matheus DeBarros

I fail and fall and try again.

I cry and scream— my soul You tend.  
Oh, humble hands please reach my heart.

Oh, evil one to you depart.

Comfort me, Oh, with Your grace.  
Dear O Lord, show me your face.

The guilt I have is heavy oh.  
Oh Haste my journey, prevent it slow.

I love you yet I fail you still.  
Lead me to your perfect will.

I wander far Oh led in shame,  
Reveal to me your holy name.  
Held by sin that weighs like chains,  
I run to you with humble praise.

Please Lord free me from my past,

Only this I dare to ask  
Forgive me father for I have sinned,  
Wash me clean Oh deep within.

Free this burden from chest.  
Please, O Lord just let me rest.



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## Once the Present

—Matheus DeBarros

Looking back and back again,  
Memories like windows to the past,  
Longing, yearning, feeling free,  
Moments we believed would always last.

Underneath the scorching sun,  
Faces burned from summer heat,

Boiling sand beneath our run,  
Stinging, blazing, tender feet  
Bring me back to joyful days,

Locked inside of winter's haze,  
To feel that feeling never leave,

To have that moment never cease  
Mind at ease— no soul to please,

To go back is all I need.  
One more moment all I ask,  
Once the present— now the past.



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# A Promise of Home

— Maurice Hunt

Walking the streets of downtown Chicago felt strange to me. Everything was black and white like the shows Mama and I would watch back in the south, where the "white only" signs were just another prop on the television. But as I walked to Auntie Elma's house for the first time in almost 10 years, it felt like the barrier between reality and fiction had been broken. Seeing the "White Only" signs made me feel as if I was no longer a part of the real world, as the signs no longer felt like recommendations but warnings. Warnings burdened with consequences that aren't worth discovering, like the sharp look Mama gives when she's at her limit. Coming from my tiny town in Georgia all the way to Chicago I expected to be ecstatic for the new life to come, but instead I was terrified. I didn't fear the unknown of the people or the abnormally large office buildings where the wealthy white men worked, but I feared the unknown my absence may cause back home. Mama was the head teacher of our small town. She taught all 7 of my sisters from the moment we were able to speak until the end of grammar school, after which we were expected to work since our little town had nothing to offer past grammar school. Mama sent me north since she believed I was the only one who could thrive on my own, and I was turning of age to go to high school. She used to call me the son she never had, from the time I beat up a boy for stealing the little change I had given my sister, to the summer my eldest sister, Bonnie, was visiting Uncle Jerome up north and Mama fell ill so I had to work the entire summer. As I walked the streets Mama's voice replayed in my head acting as a firm reminder of why I came here. I was not sent to the North to be sheltered. I was sent because she trusts me and so that I can make something more of myself. As I reached Auntie Elma's block I sat in comfort that no one seemed to notice me on my walk to her house. The city air felt less sharp and a wave of familiar warmth drifted through the air as Auntie Elma's cooking smelled as if I was back home in Georgia. The smell of collard greens and spices stuck to her clothing as she embraced me with a long-awaited hug and a kiss. Her house felt different from the rest of Chicago, and it was quiet since she lived more south of Chicago away from the busy downtown. Her house wasn't just a temporary arrangement for my schooling, it was now my home. Through a future of uncertainties home was the one thing I would count on.

# The Harvest of Open Hands

—Jackson Sidel

When fortune smiles and fills waiting hands,  
It is not ours to clutch with tightened fist,  
For blessings bloom like rain on thirsty lands,  
And fade when hoarded in a selfish mist.  
A kindness given is a seed released,  
Carried by wind to soil we may not see,  
It roots in hidden hearts and is increased,  
Returning shade to strangers and to me.  
No trumpet sounds when quiet mercies start,  
No banners wave above a humble deed,  
Yet unseen threads are stitching heart to heart,  
Binding our plenty to another's need.  
So let us pour our plenty, free and true  
For what we give, the world gives back anew.

# To pause beside a sorrow not our own

—Jackson Sidel

To pause beside a sorrow not our own,  
And feel its weight press softly on the chest,  
Is more than pity's distant, passing tone,  
It is the heart in borrowed grief at rest.  
To stand where trembling footsteps once have been,  
And see the world through unfamiliar eyes,  
Is to let quiet understanding in,  
Where judgment fades and gentler mercies rise.  
No grand display declares that we have cared,  
Empathy moves in silence, deep and slow.  
It listens first, leaves harsh conclusions spared,  
And plants compassion where harsh winds might blow.  
For when we dare another's pain to see,  
We shape a kinder shared humanity.

# More Than Just Hair

—Rylon Homer

Kinky, Curly,  
Frizzy, swirly,  
Curlicues dazzle,  
In the rain and in the sun.  
My hair is my culture,  
My hair is Black,  
My hair is brown,  
My hair is Caribbean,  
My hair is proud,  
My hair is my parents,  
My hair is legacy,  
My hair is me,  
My hair is a nest,  
That attracts bugs, birds, and bee,  
Which represent micro-aggressions  
and racial insecurities,  
"Can I touch your hair please?",  
My answer was yes, but now its no,  
And I realize,  
My hair does grow, in value that is,  
My hair is treasure,  
Safe guarded as inheritance,  
As gems for the future.



# Thank You Leave-In Conditioner

—Rylon Homer

The true tamer of curls, with moisture and aroma,  
The perfect coils and swirls, it works like no other,  
Even in mornings of catastrophe,  
You see through the eye of the frizzy storm,  
As vast and luscious as a field of wheat,  
You seem to be the true answer to my problem and solution.  
Bless my curls,  
Bless my leave-in.

## My Guiding Light

—Rylon Homer

I drill, I drill,  
I drill away for hours,  
Hoping to reach the surface,  
Where sky is clear and bright,  
Still,  
I drill, I drill,  
Through darkness, hoping to see the light.  
A guiding beacon shines the path,  
Visibility will return,  
The right way, I can finally discern,  
But wait,  
Self doubt creeps in,  
Like dark vines tangling.  
Will I make it, or not,  
Does it matter or does it not,  
My guiding light has dissipated,  
Blindness returns,  
Everything has gone aerie,  
But suddenly, it reappears,  
My guiding light, shining bright and near,  
Providing motivation in times of fear,  
I reach the top,  
I can see clearly now,  
My aspirations and hope,  
I wouldn't have done it without my big bro.



## Music Sonnet

—Chase La Pointe

When silence stretches thin across the air,  
A single note awakens hidden light,  
It trembles softly, delicate and fair,  
Then blooms into chorus full and bright.

The rhythm finds the pulse beneath the skin,  
A steady drum that echoes deep inside,  
It draws forgotten memories back in  
On waves of harmony, we can't hide.

A violin can weep what words conceal,  
A trumpet blaze with bold and golden fire,  
Through minor chords our quiet wounds can heal,  
Through swelling sound our weary hearts aspire.

For music speaks where language falls apart,  
And turns mere breath into a beating heart.

# A Trio of Haikus: Views of an Ever-Changing World

—Lucas Barkley

## Sky

Cotton candy haze  
Sky yearning for purity  
Smokestack coughs again

## Ocean

At dawn soft waves hum  
Light shimmering across blue  
A trash bag drifts by

## Land

Tall trees stand, breathing  
Animals move through green lush  
Chainsaw splits the air

## A Place To Breathe Again

—Lucas Barkley

I feel you linger softly through my days,  
A steady softness soothes away my noise.  
You don't use language, yet you speak to me,  
and in your stillness, I can breathe at last.  
You ask for nothing, only that I stay.  
To listen close, to breathe, not look away.  
When I am lost, you draw me to the ground.  
hold me there until I am whole again.

## Until the Earth Can Breathe No More

—Lucas Barkley

The river thrashes beneath the filth we pour,  
Her living pulse reduced to toxic sludge,  
The sky grows heavy with the smoke we raise,  
A poisoned weight we drive into Earth's lungs.

And still we press until the planet breaks,  
The engines of our hunger tear her raw,  
Her forests choke and wither at our touch,  
Her dying light grows dim beneath our hands.

We never meant to destroy the world she gave,  
Yet only now the cost of our actions is clear,  
And every breath she loses marks our own,  
A truth that shows how little time remains.

## The Landscape Holds its Shape Through Every Hour

—Lucas Barkley

The landscape holds its shape through every hour,  
Its ridges steady under sun and rain.  
The fields unfold without haste or power.

The river moves without force or cower,  
A measured path it follows once again.  
The landscape holds its shape through every hour.

In the forest blooms a flower,  
its leaves sway with a calm refrain,  
The fields unfold with neither haste nor power.

The mountains rise without a claim to tower,  
Their outlines are constant, simple, and humane.  
The landscape holds its shape through every hour.

The desert keeps its heat without a glower,  
Its dunes reshaped but never in disdain.  
The fields unfold with neither haste nor power.

And all of it proceeds without a vow,  
A world that moves in its unbroken chain.  
The landscape holds its shape through every hour.  
The fields unfold with neither haste nor power.

## Waiting for us to care

—Lucas Barkley

The glacier used to feel permanent.  
Standing for thousands of years,  
layer over layer of snow  
pressed into blue ice,  
holding time inside.

Now it's shrinking.  
Not like in the movies.  
Just slipping away,  
water running down its sides  
like tears.  
Chunks fall into the ocean,

a crash echoing longer  
than it should.  
Ice, once pure and solid,  
now looks tired.  
Scientists take measures  
in inches,  
in degrees,  
in charts,

with satellite images.  
The data isn't needed,  
the edges are thinner,  
the white is fading,  
the ground is showing through.  
A witness to so much extinction,  
now faces its own.  
Waiting for us to care.

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## Gas Giant

-Dominic Watson

Rings rotate 'round red  
Moons emanate melodies  
So big, so alone

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## Fishing

-Dominic Watson

Water laps the bank  
Grasshoppers disturb quiet  
Fish flutter, mouths red

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## Camping

-Dominic Watson

Heaven's light twinkles  
Eyes gaze upon unknown worlds  
Fire crackles near

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# Snow Globe

-MichaZel Montesano

There was a boy named Travis, slowly walking down a path while heavy snow was coming down. He was depressed, his head down and tears streaming down his face. Travis had a difficult day at school after getting a bad grade on his math test. His parents had been very mad and upset with his lack of effort towards this test. Travis figured with such a dreadful day he had to go outside and reset his mind. Travis' favorite sport was hockey. Whenever he was stressed out about something or needed time for himself, he would go play hockey. His favorite team in the NHL was the New Jersey Devils. Travis enjoyed going to Devils games with his dad, in fact they were season ticket holders for 15 seasons. Growing up in New Jersey and watching Devils hockey developed Travis' dream to be on the big stage playing for his favorite team. As Travis was walking down the street, he encountered a weird bubble that looked like a snow globe with little white dots floating around. Curiously, Travis entered the bubble and everything went black for 5 minutes.

Travis awoke to see the biggest jumbo-tron in the United States. Here he was in his favorite arena were the New Jersey Devils play, and he was at center ice. He could not believe what he was seeing. The first thing he did was walked to the tunnel where the players enter for the game. As he approached the locker room, he realized the door was closed and locked. Down the hallway was the Zamboni and a bunch of tools. Travis only found the skate sharpener, a saw blade, in the back of the Zamboni room, so, he took the whole machine with him. Travis put it on a cart and brought it back to the locker room. He began sawing the door down. Boom! The door fell, and there it was...everything he had dreamed about since he was little all to himself.

The first thing Travis did was go to the lounge and get something to eat. He turned the tv on and ate chicken, rice, and a smoothie. Once he was done, he went to the Devil's locker room to tie up his skates. He grabbed Jack Hughes's skates and laced them up. Travis went to the next stall and used Arseny Gritsyuk's gloves. Then, he walked up the hallway and stepped onto the ice. On the way, he grabbed the pucks and used the team captain Nico Hischier's stick. Once on the ice he took a couple warm up laps. Then he started to shoot around doing drills. Then he worked on his one timer. To finish, Travis did his favorite shoot out moves and celebrated the last shot he had taken. When he was done skating, Travis went back down the tunnel to unlace the skates. He returned everything he borrowed back to where he had found it. This time Travis went back into the players' lounge and had cookies and played video games. Naturally, his favorite video game was NHL 26. When he was done, Travis went back to the training room, got a couple of towels, and laid them down on the medical bed. One for his head and one for his body. He started to doze off.

All of a sudden Travis heard thumping from above. Boom! Boom! Boom! He blinked and opened one eye just as his mom opened the door to his bedroom. Travis woke up in his bed; after all, it was just a dream.





## Winter

—Owen Pipher

The sun sets earlier; everything gets colder.

The days become shorter.

The snow sits on the roof, and the ponds freeze.

The birds migrate; people stay inside while the animals hide.

Winter sports are played, and many people watch.

People celebrate this magical time... Winter.

# The Beach

—Owen Pipher

The waves crash along the coast, foam curling over the shore.

Some sand feels soft and powdery,  
while others feel like clay beneath my feet.

The hot sun beats down on everyone stretched out on the beach.

People surf and swim through the blue water.  
Some relax on towels and some choose chairs,  
While others toss footballs or dive for volleyballs.

No matter how you spend the day,  
Everybody finds something to love about the beach.

